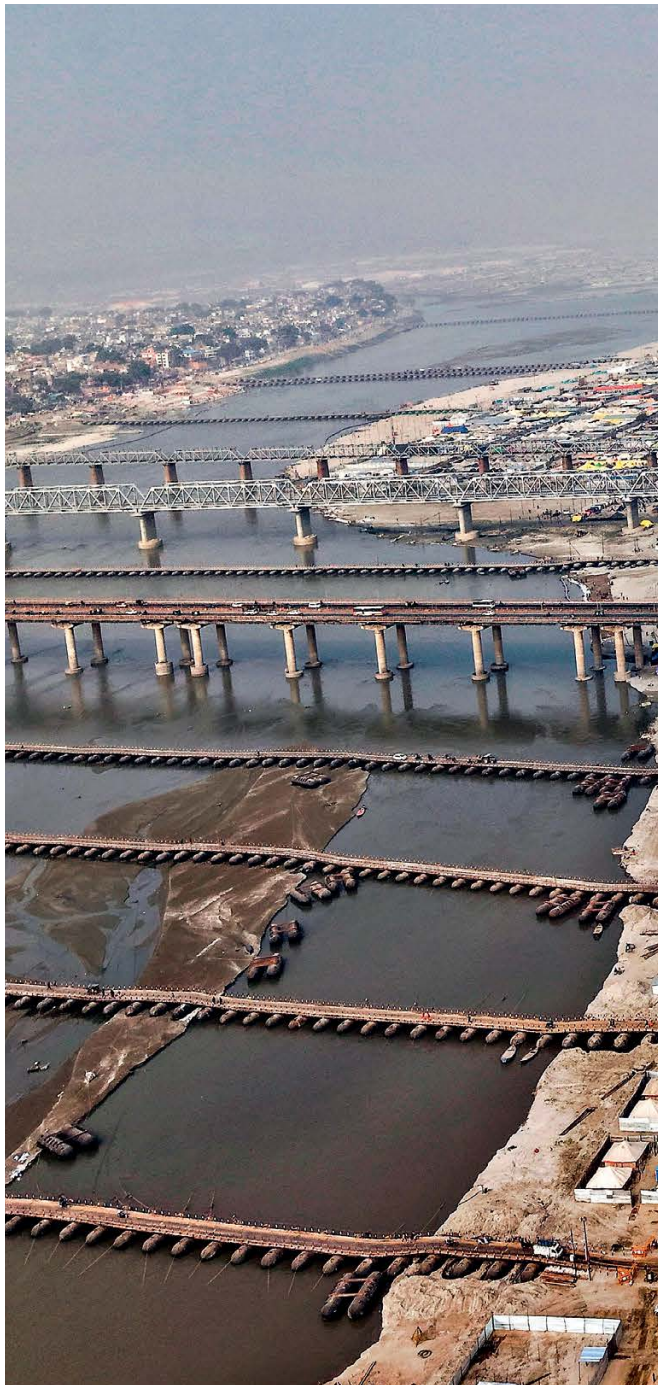
The air hums with an uncanny energy as dawn's first light touches the banks of the Triveni Sangam. Workers move with clockwork precision, hammering poles into the earth to raise a metropolis of tents. The aroma of freshly cooked food mingles with the chants of early pilgrims, while tethered drones hover above the bustling grounds like silent sentinels. This grand tableau is the arena of the Mahakumbh, just before the curtains go up. With rituals as ancient as faith itself, in its latest iteration it's also as modern as the algorithms that now help shape it. For centuries, seekers of salvation have converged on the confluence of the Ganga, Yamuna and the myth-borne Saraswati—transacting only with the transcendental. It was the 2001 edition, the first big Kumbh since the advent of the satellite era, that brought the entire world's eyes on this moment of communion.

Fast forward to 2025, and you see that audacious blend of the sacred and the digital fully nativised—a wireless data cocoon in which is enwrapped this mini-cosmos that's expanding to a never-before scale.

This marvel of modern logistics is like a spiritual hub wrapped in a wireless data cocoon: GIS maps, polyglot apps, ANPR parking tools...

The Sangam at Prayagraj keeps its date with infinity beginning January 13, the onset of an astrological phase that recurs every 12 years. Legend anoints the site as one of the four (besides Haridwar, Ujjain and Nashik) where drops of *amrit*, the nectar of immortality, spilled during the mythical churning of the oceans by *devas* and *asuras*; bathing at its ghats during this auspicious conjuncture is believed to cleanse all sins and grant *moksha*. If the foretold footfalls materialise, an astounding 450 million—more than the population of any country barring India and China—will have taken that holy dip over 48 days. To host these surreal numbers, an empty riverbank populated only by wild scrub has been turned into a mega urban conjuration. Mahakumbh Nagar, spread over 4,000 hectares, is also a magnifying glass for Uttar Pradesh's administrative mettle. In the first few foglit mornings of January, it's still in the natal ward. Pilgrims and sadhus have begun arriving in droves, their chants mingling with the clangour of the last bits of frantic construction. Greeting them is a newly laid network of temporary roads spanning 400 kilometres, 30 pontoon bridges stretching across the waters, 14 flyovers and chequered plate pathways criss-crossing a labyrinth of tents. Banners and posters are everywhere. Many flaunt the smiling visages of Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath and Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Slogans like "*Sanatan satvik hai, kaayar nahin* (sanatan is pure, not cowardly)" add a high-key ideological timbre to the spiritual philharmonic.



150,000
Public toilets, 25,000 dustbins

15,000
Sanitation workers

The Digital Kumbh

At the heart of it is another sangam—call it 'AI meets Ancient India'. In full flow, the mela grounds will transform into a kaleidoscope of spiritual rituals and timeless traditions. But the sensible way to regulate such a surge of humanity at the turnstiles is to scan its ebb and flow aerially. The *devas* may be watching from the clouds, but there will be drones surveying the moving spectacle from just above.